named Elijah Hoole visited Nagapattinam and was surprised to see in one of its streets what he described as ‘a well-executed sculpture of Buddhu, full size and seated as though in meditation’. He also saw on the town’s outskirts a ruined tower known to the British as the Silver Pagoda and a well-known landmark for sailors. It was said to have been a Buddhist temple built by a local ruler for the Chinese, and it remained standing until 1854, when it was knocked down to make way for a Jesuit seminary. But in the course of clearing the ground workmen uncovered a brick chamber under the roots of a fallen tree, which was found to contain five Buddhist bronzes. They had been buried with great care, as if for their protection, and were judged to be at least eight hundred years old. Since then more than 350 bronze statues have come to light, either from under the streets of Nagapattinam or from its immediate environs, all of them Buddhist.

Nor are these relics of the region’s Buddhist heritage confined to Nagapattinam. In the summer of 2004 a local landowner set some labourers to dig the foundations for a new house in the little village of Sellur, beside a side-channel of the Kaveri known as the Vettaru River, about 30 kilometres upstream of Thiruvarur. At a depth of six feet they came across a hoard of no fewer than forty-five Buddhist statuettes, lying face down and protected by a brick surround. All but three were metal figurines cast in copper alloy (usually but incorrectly described as bronze) using the so-called lost-wax process. Ranging in height from 7 to 52 centimetres, these ‘bronzes’ represent just about every aspect of Mahayana and Theravada Buddhism, from popular Bodhisattva figures such as Avalokiteshvara and Lokesvara to the rarer image of Maitreya, the Buddha to come.

Remarkable as the Sellur hoard is, it represents only part of the Buddhist statuary that has come to light in recent years in just this one district of Tamil Nadu alone, largely